

Congo

The Republic of Congo was a French territory until 1960. It is a hot, humid land, and its densely forested north has few inhabitants. Nearly half the country's people are members of the Kongo group; the rest include Batéké, M'Bochi, and Sangha. The mineral and timber industries have made Congo wealthy, but many people are still subsistence farmers, growing barely enough food to survive.



Coffee beans

Crops

About 50 per cent of the work-force are farmers who grow cassava, maize, rice, peanuts, and fruit to feed their families. Much food is imported. The steady export of coffee and cocoa beans has saved Congo from economic problems.



Each cocoa pod contains about 30 beans, for use in chocolate and cosmetics.

Cocoa pods

Animal skin is stretched across the drum.



Drum

An essential part of African life, drums are used for signalling as well as for music.

Most drums are intricately carved out of a solid piece of wood and can be decorated with different woods and hides. Drums are made in all shapes and sizes – this one is almost as tall as the player.

Industry

Oil from the Atlantic Ocean accounts for 90 per cent of Congo's exports, contributing largely to the country's wealth. Fluctuating oil prices have caused some economic problems, but Congo's crop exports have remained strong. The felling of forests to export tropical timber is a pressing environmental concern. Huge barges on the Congo and other rivers carry timber goods as far as Brazzaville; from there the Congo Ocean Railway takes them to Pointe Noire, Congo's only port.

CONGO FACTS

CAPITAL CITY	Brazzaville
AREA	341,500 sq km (131,853 sq miles)
POPULATION	2,900,000
MAIN LANGUAGES	French, Kongo
MAJOR RELIGIONS	Christian, traditional beliefs
CURRENCY	CFA franc



Gabon

A palm-fringed sandy coastline 800 km (500 miles) long, and lush tropical vegetation dominate Gabon's landscape. The country earns 80 per cent of its foreign currency from oil and also sells timber, manganese, and uranium ore. Gabon has the potential to be wealthy, but mismanagement by the government has led to continued poverty.

Woman in Libreville, Gabon's capital



Libreville

The bustling port city of Libreville was founded in 1849 by French naval officers. Meaning "free town" in French, Libreville was a new home for liberated slaves. It is now a modern, growing city, and a centre of culture, industry, and government. Many citizens are wealthy, but poverty still exists.



People

Although Gabon is one of Africa's most thinly populated countries, it contains more than 40 different ethnic groups. The indigenous Fang people form the largest group. Once fierce warriors, they now dominate the government. Most Gabonese people are Christians, and about 90 per cent of their children attend primary schools. The Gabonese traditions of dance, song, poetry, and story-telling remain an important social and cultural part of everyday life.



The Trans-Gabon Railway runs from Libreville to Franceville.

Trans-Gabon Railway

Opened in 1986 to transport gold and manganese, the Trans-Gabon Railway has caused much controversy because it cut through rainforest, destroying many valuable and rare trees.

Equatorial Guinea

Two former Spanish colonies make up the country of Equatorial Guinea, located close to the Equator. Río Muni, also called Mbini, is on mainland Africa, and Bioko Island, which has fertile, volcanic soil that is ideal for growing cocoa beans, is situated to the northwest, off the coast of neighbouring Cameroon.

Traditional healing

Like other Africans, many people in Equatorial Guinea believe that illness is due to the influence of bad spirits. Professional healers use dancing and chants to drive out the evil spirits. They keep a range of animal bones, shells, sticks, and other plant parts in their medicine bags for use in group ceremonies.



Hippopotamus tooth



Cowrie shell



Tree root

Animal bone



Extended families

Among the people of Equatorial Guinea there is a strong tradition of large, extended families, who stay together and help one another in times of hardship.

EQUATORIAL GUINEA FACTS

CAPITAL CITY	Malabo
AREA	28,050 sq km (10,830 sq miles)
POPULATION	453,000
MAIN LANGUAGES	Spanish, Bubi, Fang
MAJOR RELIGION	Christian
CURRENCY	CFA franc